Woods institutions were created and contribute to global growth at higher rates than most advanced industrial economies, and that all the original BRICs have risen into the top ranks of the world's economies, they have had to settle for a global institutional architecture that represents an earlier distribution of economic power. Such sizable gaps revealed the extent to which such institutions have been resistant to change, particularly by incumbent members of the G7, who have blocked a redistribution of roles and influence.[93] In practice, the distribution of voting and quota shares reflect a host of other obscure formal rules, such as the formulas to measure voting power, as well as informal practices that help protect the incumbent powers' dominant positions and often discriminate against emerging economies, such as those of the BRICS.

The second aspect of club theory, which focuses on the narrower operationalization of the club model, better explains how groups of leading powers have emerged and function. In his definitive study of club model politics, Daniel Drezner explains why the incumbent powers created and seek to preserve the G7. As the premier club in which incumbent powers can bypass the formal rules of international institutions, the G7 ensures that "decisions are made by powerful states behind closed doors" and helps control their implementation.[94] Drezner shows how the process of creating and enforcing global financial regulation, like trade, conforms to a club standards model where the G7 states first achieve a concert in private and then work to have international financial institutions (such as the IMF) serve as enforcers.[95]

Because the benefits of financial regulatory coordination were higher and adjustment costs lower for the advanced powers compared to emerging economies, it was easier to reach a consensus. Other scholars underscore the point that clubs like the G7 have broad framing and agenda-setting powers; advantageous positions with respect to information and expertise, which boost their power of endorsement; and veto power, in that they can block other initiatives by not supporting them.[96] However, in some cases, such as macroeconomic policy coordination, the G7 was often deadlocked, as the United States and other members each tried to pass the adjustment costs of policy coordination on to the others.[97]

The G7 (sometimes in slightly smaller or larger groups of the Western leading powers) has met regularly for decades, either at the level of leaders'